

Book Review:

Book's Name: Of Blood and Fire: The Untold Story of Bangladesh's War of Independence

Author: Jahanara Imam

Translator: Mustafizur Rahman

Publisher: The University Press Limited

Publishing Year: 1998

I chose the book "Of Blood and Fire: The Untold Story of Bangladesh's War of Independence" because it contains the firsthand experience of someone who directly witnessed the events of the independent war. As a Bangladeshi, the history of the liberation war has always been the center of my attraction, and to get knowledge of it, what could be better than reading the personal experience of a person who witnessed the war in person?

This book covers the period of independent war of Bangladesh and its prehistories happened in between 1947 to 1971.

To start with, the socio- economic discrimination faced by East Pakistan is one of the central themes of this book. Firstly, the Language Movement from 1948 to 1952 was one of these crucial issues. Though Bangla was the mother tongue of the majority in East Pakistan, Muhammad Ali Jinnah, the General Governor of that time,

declared in 1948 that Urdu would be the sole state language of the whole Pakistan. This declaration triggered the Bengali speaking people. On 21 February 1952, when students were killed, it left a permanent mark on the identity of Bengalis (Imam, 1998). This movement united the people of East Pakistan and solidified their cultural identity. Moreover, they attacked the culture of East Pakistan. Efforts to weaken Bengali literature, art, and music. West Pakistanis owned most of the mills and factories, while East Pakistanis were playing the low-paying labor roles. This economic exploitation created a sense of cultural and social inferiority that fueled resentment (Sengupta, 2011).

Then again, the political events increased the tensions. In the 1954 election, the United Front defeated the Muslim League for the first time and wanted to get more control over their motherland, East Pakistan. But it went to vain when General Ayub Khan imposed martial law in 1958. The new constitution in 1956, which declared Pakistan an Islamic republic, increased divisions by prioritizing central control over provincial autonomy (Imam, 1998). The "Six Point Movement" of 1966 and the "Mass Uprising" of 1969 angered the people even more. In the following year, when the election of 1970 occurred, the Awami League, led by Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, won overwhelmingly, securing 167 seats out of 169 seats.

However, Yahya Khan refused to transfer the power, which had created more enmity among the people.

Lastly, the religious unfairness West Pakistan did with East Pakistan added fuel to the fire. From the creation of Pakistan in 1947, people in West Pakistan were viewed as superior in culture and religion. Whereas, people in East Pakistan were inferior due to their language and culture. Sometimes they even treated the people of East Pakistan like they were not true muslim. These themes of religious division made their biased control system look like completely correct in both politics and society. The government created policies that excluded Bengali Muslims and saw East Pakistan as a lesser province. Forcing people to act based on religion only deepened the divide. Then, East Pakistanis started to feel more linked to their Bengali roots than to their imposed religious identity (Sengupta, 2011).

"Of Blood and Fire: The Untold Story of Bangladesh's War of Independence" is an important story of events leading to the independence of Bangladesh. Jahanara Imam expresses her personal experiences along with historical data to highlight the hardships and the sacrifices of the Bengali citizens at the hands of West Pakistan. The book represents the social, economic, political, and cultural problems faced by East Pakistan and the strength and unity of its people in the struggle for independence. This is not just a history book, rather, it is an honor given to the courage of freedom fighters. It really reminds one to respect the hard-earned freedom of Bangladesh.

References:

Imam, J. (1998). *Of blood and fire: The untold story of Bangladesh's war of independence* (M. Rahman, Trans.). The University Press Limited.

Sengupta, N. (2011). *Land of two rivers: A history of Bengal from the Mahabharata to Mujib*. Penguin India.